

New abnormal

AS I WRITE THIS COLUMN THE SECOND WAVE OF COVID HAS BEEN DEVASTATING FOR DIGIT, WITH SO MANY OF OUR COLLEAGUES DOWN WITH COVID, some being hospitalised themselves, or having to care for family members who have contracted it. Sadly we've even had some colleagues whose family members have lost the fight against this dreaded virus, and our heart goes out to them and all of you readers who are also struggling with this pandemic, or worse, have lost someone you loved to it.

I live in a privileged bubble in Western Australia, where the entire state has lived almost COVID free for the last year. Seeing what my family, friends, colleagues, and you readers are going through in India is horrifying for me, and I find myself overreacting rather angrily to anti-vaccine groups and anti-mask protesters here...

This privileged idiocy is not the point of my column though.

The idea for this column arose during a call with the team, about the new abnormal. The pandemic is not going anywhere soon. Even after the world is vaccinated new variants are bound to crop up, and tracking them is going to be a nightmare. What's abundantly clear is that we will not be able to take for granted so many of the things that we did before 2020, and so many businesses and verticals are going to be forever altered.

When we were discussing it, the most obvious ones were things like Airbnb and ridesharing. When the day comes where we're thinking about vacations and travel again, most of us are going to want to keep safe and stay at places that we can trust to clean and sanitise rooms, such as hotels. Not only are many travellers not going to want to stay at shared accommodation, many people who were sharing their homes with travellers are not going to want to risk being infected. The travel industry as a whole is going to take a long time to recover. Safety regulations might lead to air travel not being as cramped an affair as before, but industry experts say it will revert to sardines-in-a-can as soon as borders allow unrestricted travel. It will take a few years though, before prices plummet again and airports are as busy as pre-covid days.

Rideshares, on the other hand, carry far more risk. While airlines can demand COVID negative tests and measure temperatures before you board, there's no way your average Ola or Uber driver is equipped to deal with that headache.

This is going to make travel across our big cities a lot harder. Hopefully governments will take the initiative and rush to improve the public transport systems and increase the options people have.

Of course, while international travel might suffer, domestic travel might benefit. India is a vast and beautiful country, and I am one of the many people who is guilty of travelling more across the world than I have within India. This will, hopefully, change now.

One of the few good things to come from the pandemic is that we realised how much of our work can be done remotely, so long as we have good internet access. Speaking of which, the rush to improve the internet backbones across the globe to deal with this scattered demand for bandwidth in the suburbs was also a good thing. Instead of focusing on commercial centres and business areas of cities, we've ended up with pretty decent speeds and reliability from most of our homes.

Another thing that will not be the same is outings. Whether it's movie theatres, sporting events, socialising in crowded bars, discos... any event where there are thousands of people in attendance will have to factor in social distancing, disinfection, careful crowd management etc., which will make them a pain to organise. Smaller businesses will also be negatively affected, such as bars, cafes, restaurants, etc., as their profit margins aren't built to handle the cost of cleaning and disinfecting everything and social distancing.

What the pandemic has done, however, is open up every single vertical that we thought had been closed by monopolies to disruption. There is opportunity to innovate with creative solutions to more than just the problems I've mentioned above. Opportunities abound in remote education, remote employee management, biometrics, security, dating apps, service providers, converting real events into virtual ones, more localised services, more automation and less human interaction at point of sales... that last one might not be the most desirable, but thankfully the world has been reminded of how important human interaction is. Not taking our friends, family (especially parents and grandparents), and colleagues for granted. Hopefully the new abnormal will cause us to appreciate human interaction more, and not take time with people for granted ever again. Then again, maybe I'm expecting too much... 



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